

Old Testament





About the Course

Students in Grades 3-6 read Old Testament narratives chronologically. For 2026-2027, students read selections from Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and 1-2 Samuel. Lesson plans also include selections from maps and books such as The New Manners and Customs of Bible Times, which teachers can read or share with their students to help them understand the biblical context and gain insight into the culture and geography of Israel.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Bible: Grade 3, Bible: Grades 4-6



Placement & Combining Tips

Suitable for older students if combining lessons, and ideal for older students just getting familiar with the Bible.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
3-6	Old Testament: Grades 3-6 2 times/week 20 min	ESV Large Print Bible The Student Bible Atlas, Revised Edition The New Manners and Customs of Bible Times

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Bible: Grade 3				
Old Testament: Grades 3-6	New Testament: Grades 3-6	Old Testament: Grades 3-6	New Testament: Grades 3-6	Church History: Grades 1-3
Bible: Grades 4-6				
Old Testament: Grades 3-6	New Testament: Grades 3-6	Old Testament: Grades 3-6	New Testament: Grades 3-6	Church History: Grades 4-6



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Old Testament: Grades 3-6



ESV Large Print Bible



The Student Bible Atlas, Revised Edition



The New Manners and Customs of Bible Times



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Related Course Quick Links

- ∞ [Extra Helpings](#)
- ∞ [Foundations \(See Section 6: Bible\)](#)
- ∞ [How can we find the original meaning of the text?](#)
- ∞ [How do we help students learn to interpret the Bible?](#)
- ∞ [How does learning about the Ancient Near East world help us understand the Bible?](#)
- ∞ [What is the role of the Holy Spirit when reading the Bible?](#)

Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.



Old Testament: Grades 3-6

How To Teach



Recap

- Connect to previous lessons by asking students to recall where they left off.
- If students have difficulty recalling, teachers might try showing them a picture from the reading, sharing something the teacher remembers, or prompting them with the first sentence of the last reading. This will often refresh their memory enough to allow them to recall.
- If students still cannot recall anything from the last reading, teachers might consider continuing anyway (with a shorter reading this time) or repeating the previous lesson, depending on the reading and the nature of the book.



Read

- Read the chapter or selection aloud. When reading to pre-readers, point to the words as you read, even if it seems they aren't paying attention.
- Move at the students' pace during the lesson, rather than feeling that a particular number of pages must be completed. It is vitally important that teachers not overload students with more material than they can absorb in one sitting.
- Students who have difficulty sitting still or listening may benefit from a fidget of their choice, such as a piece of putty or clay or an afghan; flexible positioning, such as a wobble seat or inverted sitting; or sensory modulation, such as a weighted vest or blanket or adjustment of light, temperature, or sound.
- Students with regular difficulty engaging often benefit from having a picture to associate with the story WHILE listening. Feel free to view the artwork during the reading rather than after the narration.



Narrate

- Have students retell the passage orally.
- Alternatively, learners may use words, pictures, Legos, dolls, etc., to process and convey ideas in the manner most natural to them.
- Teachers may take turns to model.
- Narration is a complex skill requiring the coordination of several parts of the brain. If a student struggles to narrate in general, with a specific subject or book, or on one day but not others, then this is an opportunity to learn. Observe when they struggle with this or any other activity today. Notice facial expressions and body language; listen to what they say about why it is hard or how they feel about it. Take note of these observations for later, tell them that you see how hard they are working, and then offer whatever support they need to end on a positive note. If necessary, take a break for the day.



View

- Optional: Share a piece of fine art that illustrates the story.



Discuss

- Give students an opportunity to share their thoughts on the lesson and any connections made.
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Old Testament: Grades 3-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 1

Introduction to Joshua

 Materials: ESV Large Print Bible, notebook

PREP: The teacher may wish to read the article linked here that explains the genre of Historical or Historical Narrative books of the Bible. The focus is always on who God is (known as the theology of God) while the history of his people is told.

∞ Article Link: [Introduction to the Old Testament Historical Books](#)

→ INTRO

This year in the Old Testament, we will read five books: Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 and 2 Samuel. These books continue the story of Israel so that when we open our Bible to the book of Joshua, it is as though we are starting to read in the middle of a story where important events and people have already been introduced and discussed.

In order to understand what is going to happen next, let's do a short review of what has happened so far. The first five books of the Bible are a group of books called the Pentateuch. The Pentateuch is the books of Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. The next set, or category, has twelve books in it and is called Historical or Historical Narrative. We will read the first five of these books this year. Historical narrative books show us who God is while the story of his people, the Israelites, is told. When you read a historical narrative book, you will see that it answers the question, "And then what happened?"

What do you recall about what has happened so far in the life of Israel? (Students may mention Abraham, Moses, being in Egypt, plagues in Egypt, crossing the Red Sea, etc.)

Leaders of Israel have included Abraham, who received a promise from God that He would bless him with land, people, and many blessings. Next, the nation of Israel was led by Moses. Moses led the people as they escaped from Egypt, crossed the Red Sea, and wandered in the wilderness.

God made a covenant (promise) with Moses that if the people followed God, they would be blessed. But if they disobeyed, they would be cursed (things would not go well for them). For today's reading, we are going to read a passage from the book of Deuteronomy where the covenant God made with Moses is written about. As we read Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, these promises will be underlying the decisions the people and leaders of Israel make, so it is an important chapter to keep in our minds as we read. Will they continue to follow God, or will they forget about him and turn to their own selfish ways? We will find out as we read the Historical Narrative books and find out the answer to "And then what happened?"

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

Deuteronomy 28:1-10, 15-19, 25

- What did God promise (or covenant) with the people of Israel?

→ NOTEBOOK

This year, you will keep a notebook. Suggestions will be given in lessons for drawing or writing what you have read about, but you can always add drawings or writings of your own choosing as well.

Today, open up your notebook and create a title page with the heading: Old Testament.

As time and ability allow, write the names of the books we will be covering this year: Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel, and 2 Samuel. You can also write the genre of these books: Historical Narrative.

Old Testament: Grades 3-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 2

Joshua Commissioned

 Materials: ESV Large Print Bible, notebook, Student Bible Atlas

→ RECAP

What do you recall about the intro to Joshua from last time?

→ INTRO

Before he died, Moses passed on the leadership of the people of Israel to Joshua (Deut. 31:7-8). In today's reading, Joshua will speak to the people about entering the Promised Land—the nation of Canaan. As Joshua speaks, he reminds the people of what they should do to have success and blessings. He also says, "Be strong and courageous." The reason the people could be strong and courageous is because the Lord was going with them and preparing their way. As we read, count how many times you hear this phrase or words similar to this.

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

Joshua 1:1-18

- How many times did he say "Be strong and courageous"? Why do you think he repeated that command?
- How would you feel if you were an Israelite about to enter the Promised Land?

→ MAP WORK

 Map Resource: Student Bible Atlas p.8-9 Maps 4 and 5

1. At the end of Deuteronomy, we are told that before he died, Moses "went up from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo" (Deut. 34:1) and was shown the Promised Land. On Map 4 (the larger map), locate Moab, the Jordan River (labeled as "R. Jordan"), and Canaan.
2. Look at the image in the bottom right-hand corner to see the view from Mount Nebo.
3. Looking at Map 5, locate Mt Nebo and the Jordan River. Follow the arrows to see the direction the Israelites will move forward in the book of Joshua. The Jordan River moves north to south, and to the east is a plateau (mostly flat, level ground) and mountains to the left. The people are approaching Canaan from the south. The first move they will have to make is to cross the Jordan River.

→ NOTEBOOK

In your notebook, create a title page for the book of Joshua. Draw a picture of Joshua speaking to the Israelites as their new leader. As time and ability allow, write the phrase "Be strong and courageous." Older students might write a short summary of the passage or a key verse from the passage.

WEEK 2 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 3

Rahab Hides the Spies

 Materials: ESV Large Print Bible; Manners & Customs of Bible Times

NOTE: Two different options are given for the reading from Manners & Customs. Choose which one best fits the age or the interests of your student(s). This book will be used throughout the year to give background explanation of the customs of the people at the time. Because the book covers the entire Bible, at times other verses will be referenced, but selections have been chosen to give background to the Old Testament books we are reading.



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→ RECAP

What do you recall about what we read last time?

→ INTRO

Joshua is going to send two spies into the land to check it out. Maybe he thought back to how he had once been a spy for Moses!

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

Joshua 2:1-24

- Deuteronomy 28:10 says, "And all the peoples of the earth shall see that you are called by the name of the Lord, and they shall be afraid of you." How does what Rahab says and does agree with (or prove) this verse from Deuteronomy? (If needed, see Josh. 2:9-11, 24)

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

Rahab's family lived in a house that was part of the walls of Jericho. Read the following passage for an idea of what this may have looked like.

Manners & Customs "Brick Houses"

Younger students: View the illustrations and read p.28 "When the semi-nomadic" - "stone was white."; p.30-31 "The flat roof" - "in Matthew 24:17."

Older students, or as time and interest allow: View the illustrations and read p.28-31 "When the semi-nomadic" - "in Matthew 24:17."

WEEK 2 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 4

Crossing the Jordan

Materials: ESV Large Print Bible, notebook

→ RECAP

What do you recall about what we read in Joshua last time?

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

Joshua 3:7-17; 4:15-24

- How would the stones help the children (or future generations) remember what happened at the Jordan River? If you were there and someone asked you what the stones were for, what would you answer?
- What do God's miracles tell us about God?

→ NOTEBOOK

Draw a picture or write a short summary of today's passage. Older students may pick a key verse or phrase from today's reading to write as well.

WEEK 3 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 5

The Walls Fall

Materials: ESV Large Print Bible, notebook

→ RECAP

What do you recall about what we read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE & DISCUSS

1. Israel celebrates Passover and remembers how God has delivered them from Egypt.

Read Joshua 5:10-15.

- In verse 12, it says the manna stopped. How do you think the Israelites felt about that?

2. Read Joshua 6:1-19.

Jericho is the first city the Israelites need to conquer, as Jericho protects



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the entry into the land from the east, where they crossed the Jordan. Scholars say Jericho "was about a twelve-acre site...[and] Based on the size of the site today, it seems that it might have taken Joshua's army less than half an hour to march around the city walls...In the ancient world every war was holy war because people believed that their gods called them to war, led them in battle, and fought on their behalf...For this assault it was the ark and the priests that gave indication of God's presence with the Israelites and made it plain that the battle belonged to the Lord." (Bible Story Handbook, Walton) Usually, when an army defeated a city or people, they would take the plunder or goods (such as jewelry and anything that was worth a lot). In this case, the people did not take anything, because it wasn't they that claimed the victory—it was God who won this battle.

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Sound of the Shofar

View the video showing various Jewish people blowing the shofar, the ram's horn trumpet that was used in Israel's history—and is still used today—to call people to worship. What would it have been like to hear this sound if you were part of the army marching around Jericho?

→ NOTEBOOK

Draw a picture or write a short summary of what you read today. Older students might write out a key verse from this passage or write a longer summary.

WEEK 3 20m Old Testament: Grades 3-6 - Lesson 6

Achan's Sin

📖 Materials: ESV Large Print Bible; Manners & Customs

→ RECAP

What do you recall about what we read last time?

→ INTRO

Last time, we saw that the people did not take any of the plunder from Jericho as they were directed by God: "But all silver and gold, and every vessel of bronze and iron, are holy to the Lord; they shall go into the treasury of the Lord." (6:19) The word "plunder" means the valuables or possessions that would be taken from the people defeated in war. Armies that won battles would take the plunder not only to celebrate the victory, but to add the loot to their money pile so they could afford to keep battling! After the battle at Jericho, everyone followed this rule and listened...except Achan.

→ READ & NARRATE

Joshua 7:1-25

"When Achan took goods as plunder, it was like making a claim that the Israelites had won the battle rather than the Lord."

→ READ & DISCUSS

Manners & Customs of the Bible "War and religion" (See note above.) p.268-269 "It was not" - "his own people."

★ TEACHER NOTE

Preview verses 24 and 25, where Achan and his family are killed because of his disobedience.

Preview Manners & Customs reading regarding warfare. Either summarize or skip the couple of sentences that may not be appropriate for younger students.